INTERCONTINENTAL
AVIATION ACADEMY

FLYIAA JOURNAL

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Inspiring the Future of Flight

Your Dream FlyIAA

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Note from the global chairman Captain Wissam Al Mehyou

At FlyIAA, our mission has always gone beyond flight training. We are committed to shaping future aviation professionals who are prepared to lead with knowledge, discipline, innovation, and global perspective. Seeing our students progress, our instructors excel, and our academies expand their impact continues to be a source of great pride for all of us.

Academy news & milestones

FlyIAA Launches Pilot Training Program at AUIB

FlyIAA has reached an important milestone with the successful launch of its pilot training pathway at American University of Iraq, Baghdad. Through this collaboration, students now have the opportunity to begin their journey toward obtaining an EASA pilot license while pursuing their academic studies.

The initiative reflects a shared commitment to developing the next generation of aviation professionals by combining world-class education with internationally recognized flight training. Students enrolled in the program will benefit from a structured pathway that introduces them to the foundations of aviation while preparing them for future flight training opportunities under European aviation standards.

This partnership represents another step forward in FlyIAA's mission to make high-quality aviation education more accessible across the region and create new opportunities for aspiring pilots.

Academy news & milestones

FlyIAA Announces Expansion into Syria

In another exciting development, FlyIAA has announced plans to expand its presence into Syria, marking a significant step in the academy's regional growth strategy.

The expansion aims to provide aspiring pilots and aviation professionals in Syria with greater access to internationally recognized aviation education and training opportunities. By extending its reach into new markets, FlyIAA continues to strengthen its position as a leading aviation training provider across the Middle East.

Further details regarding programs, partnerships, and training opportunities will be announced in the coming months. The initiative reflects FlyIAA's ongoing commitment to supporting aviation development, creating educational opportunities, and helping meet the growing demand for qualified aviation professionals throughout the region.

Student spotlight

First Solo Success for Simao Antunes and Tom Heller

A pilot's first solo flight is one of the most memorable and rewarding moments in flight training. It marks the transition from learning under the guidance of an instructor to taking full command of the aircraft independently.

This month, Simao Antunes successfully completed his first solo flight, demonstrating the confidence, skill, and professionalism required to reach this important stage of training. His achievement reflects countless hours of study, preparation, and practice, as well as their commitment to continuous improvement.

The first solo is more than just a flight—it is a milestone that every pilot remembers throughout their career, and Simao should be proud of this remarkable accomplishment.

Student spotlight

In another outstanding achievement, Khaled Harmouch successfully earned his Private Pilot License (PPL) in just 3.5 months, completing the program in record time.

Earning a PPL requires a strong understanding of aviation theory, practical flight skills, and the ability to consistently perform to international training standards. Khaled's exceptional focus, discipline, and determination enabled him to progress through the program at an impressive pace while maintaining the high level of proficiency expected of FlyIAA students.

His accomplishment serves as a testament to what can be achieved through dedication, hard work, and a clear commitment to one's aviation goals.

Congratulations to Simao, and Khaled on these outstanding achievements. We look forward to following their continued success as they advance in their aviation careers and reach new heights in the skies ahead.

Instructor insights

Active Communication: One of the Most Important Skills a Pilot Can Develop

In aviation, communication is far more than simply speaking over the radio. It is a critical safety skill that every pilot must continuously develop.
One of the most valuable habits student pilots can build early in training is active communication. This means listening carefully, speaking clearly, asking questions when uncertain, and maintaining constant awareness of the environment around them.
Many students focus primarily on aircraft control and technical procedures, but effective communication often becomes the difference between confusion and confidence in the cockpit. Whether communicating with instructors, air traffic controllers, crew members, or fellow students, clarity and professionalism are essential at every stage of flight training.
A common mistake among student pilots is hesitating to speak up when they do not fully understand something. In reality, strong pilots are not the ones who pretend to know everything. They are the ones who actively seek clarification, verify information, and communicate openly under pressure.
Active communication also improves teamwork and situational awareness. Instructors can better guide students who communicate their thought process during training flights, while students themselves become more confident decision-makers when they verbalize procedures and intentions clearly.

As aviation environments become increasingly fast-paced and technologically advanced, communication skills remain one of the most human and irreplaceable aspects of flying.

Flight science & Innovation

How Airlines Are Improving Ground Operations with Smart Airport Maps

Airports are among the most complex and high-risk environments in aviation, making efficient ground operations essential for both safety and performance. To help pilots navigate busy airports more effectively, Jeppesen ForeFlight has introduced new enhancements to its FliteDeck Pro electronic flight bag (EFB) through Smart Airport Maps technology.

One of the latest features is Graphical NOTAMs, which visually display important airport updates such as closed taxiways and runways directly on airport maps. Instead of relying only on lengthy text reports, pilots can instantly identify restrictions through simple visual indicators, reducing workload and improving situational awareness.

The development of Smart Airport Maps began after a major runway accident in Taipei in 2000 highlighted the need for better airport navigation tools. Since then, the system has expanded from covering just 25 airports to more than 1,240 airports worldwide.

The platform now also uses ADS-B data and machine learning to estimate taxi times in real time. This allows pilots to make more efficient operational decisions, such as taxiing on a single engine to reduce fuel consumption and operating costs.

In addition, airlines can customize airport maps with their own operational procedures and guidance, improving coordination between crews and ground operations.

By providing pilots with clearer, real-time airport information, Smart Airport Maps are helping airlines improve safety, reduce delays, lower fuel costs, and create a more efficient experience for both crews and passengers.

Source:
flightglobal.com/paid-content/2026/04/how-airlines-achieve-more-efficient-ground-operations-with-jeppesen-smart-airport-maps/

Industry trends & global aviation outlook

AI in Aviation: Why Strategic Implementation Matters

Artificial Intelligence is becoming increasingly integrated into the aviation industry, supporting areas such as predictive maintenance, fleet management, crew scheduling, and air traffic optimization. These technologies are helping airlines improve efficiency, reduce delays, and streamline operations.

However, unlike many digital industries, aviation operates within extremely tight financial margins and strict safety regulations. This means airlines must approach AI investments carefully, focusing on solutions that deliver clear operational and financial benefits rather than experimental technologies with uncertain returns.

Because aviation is a safety-critical industry, AI systems must also remain transparent and closely monitored. Airlines cannot rely on fully automated "black box" systems, especially in areas connected to flight operations, maintenance, or crew management. Human oversight continues to play a vital role in ensuring safety and accountability.

Industry experts emphasize that the most effective AI strategies are those implemented gradually and with discipline. Many airlines are already seeing success through lower-risk applications in administrative and back-office operations, while larger opportunities are emerging in revenue management, maintenance planning, inventory forecasting, and operational decision-making.

Rather than replacing aviation professionals, AI is currently being used to support faster decisions, improve efficiency, identify operational opportunities, and enhance overall performance — while keeping human expertise at the center of the process.

Source:
fticonsulting.com/insights/articles/global-aviation-themes-2026-key-trends

Featured article

90 Years After Its First Flight, the Spitfire Is Set to Be Reborn

The legendary Supermarine Spitfire, first flown in 1936 and made iconic during the Second World War, is set for a modern revival through a new-build replica program.

A UK-based initiative is developing the Aerolite Spitfire Type 433, a two-seat recreation inspired by the original design but built with modern composite materials and updated avionics. Unlike historic airframes that require extensive maintenance and storage, the new version is designed to be more durable, cost-efficient, and suitable for private ownership.

The project aims to offer a more accessible alternative to original Spitfires, which today can cost around $4 million and are extremely rare. The replica is expected to be significantly less expensive, targeting aviation enthusiasts and private syndicates seeking a heritage flying experience.

While still in development and seeking investment for full production, the prototype has already been built and is planned to tour air shows and aviation events across the UK to generate interest.

If successful, the project could mark a rare blend of historic aviation design with modern aerospace technology — keeping the spirit of the Spitfire alive for a new generation of pilots and enthusiasts.

Source: simpleflying.com/spitfire-reborn-90-years-first-flight/

World aviation news

Planes Were Just the Beginning: The World's First Pokémon Airport Takes Off

Japan is taking aviation branding to a new level as Noto Satoyama Airport prepares to become a fully themed Pokémon airport this July.

From July 2026 to September 2029, the airport will be temporarily renamed "Noto Satoyama Pokémon with You Airport", featuring official Pokémon artwork, redesigned spaces, and a new logo highlighting Pikachu alongside local cultural elements. It is expected to be the first airport in the world officially named after Pokémon.

Inside the terminal, passengers will see large-scale installations including flying-type Pokémon displays, themed staircases, and a suspended Pikachu balloon in the main atrium. Over 100 Pokémon characters will be integrated throughout the airport experience to create a highly immersive environment.

The project is also part of a wider regional recovery effort following the 2024 earthquake, aiming to boost tourism and bring energy back to the area.

Today, the airport remains a domestic connection point to Tokyo Haneda, operated by ANA, but its upcoming transformation is set to make it a unique aviation and pop-culture landmark.

Source: simpleflying.com/worlds-first-pokemon-airport/

FlyIAA course

Private Pilot License (PPL): Your First Step Into the World of Aviation

Every airline captain, commercial pilot, and aviation professional begins with a single milestone: earning a Private Pilot License (PPL).
At FlyIAA, the PPL program is designed to provide aspiring pilots with a flexible and internationally recognized pathway into aviation. By combining local ground school training with flight training at certified international bases, students can begin their aviation journey closer to home while preparing for a global future.

The program starts at one of FlyIAA's ground training locations across the region, where students complete the theoretical knowledge required for pilot certification. Once they have successfully completed this phase, they move to one of FlyIAA's certified flight training bases in Europe or the Middle East to undertake practical flight training and earn either an EASA or ICAO Private Pilot License.
This unique training model makes professional pilot education more accessible while maintaining the highest international standards. Students pursuing the ICAO route also have the flexibility to convert their license to an EASA qualification later, opening additional opportunities for international flying and career progression.

Throughout the program, students develop a strong foundation in aviation through subjects including Air Law, Aircraft General Knowledge, Flight Performance and Planning, Human Performance, Meteorology, Navigation, Operational Procedures, Principles of Flight, and Aviation Communications.

Beyond technical knowledge, the PPL course helps students develop critical skills such as decision-making, situational awareness, discipline, and confidence in the cockpit. Upon graduation, pilots are qualified to fly independently or carry passengers for private purposes while building the experience necessary for advanced pilot training.
For many students, the PPL is more than a license—it is the beginning of a lifelong passion for aviation. Whether the goal is recreational flying or progressing toward a Frozen Airline Transport Pilot License (f-ATPL), the Private Pilot License serves as the essential first step.

Frequently asked question

What are the medical requirements for pilot training? Can I become a pilot if I wear glasses?

Yes — wearing glasses or contact lenses does not prevent you from becoming a pilot, as long as your vision meets the required aviation standards after correction. To begin most professional pilot training programs, you must pass a Class 1 Medical Examination, which is a mandatory requirement set by aviation authorities such as European Union Aviation Safety Agency. This medical certificate confirms that a pilot is physically and mentally fit to safely operate an aircraft under commercial conditions.

The Class 1 Medical is a comprehensive assessment that goes beyond eyesight. It typically includes evaluations of your vision, hearing, cardiovascular health, neurological function, and overall physical fitness. Psychological well-being and the ability to perform under stress may also be considered, as aviation requires high levels of concentration, decision-making, and situational awareness.
Regarding vision specifically, candidates are allowed to wear corrective lenses (glasses or contact lenses) if their eyesight can be corrected to meet the required standards. This is very common in aviation, and many licensed pilots rely on corrective lenses throughout their careers.

If you pass the vision requirements with correction, there is no restriction on becoming a pilot. However, your medical certificate will include a limitation stating that you must wear corrective lenses while flying. This is simply a safety note to ensure that visual standards are always maintained during flight operations.

It is also important to understand that the Class 1 Medical is not a one-time requirement. Pilots must renew it periodically throughout their careers, ensuring continued fitness to fly as they progress from training to commercial aviation.

In short, good eyesight, whether natural or corrected, combined with overall medical fitness, is what matters. Wearing glasses is completely acceptable, and for many professional pilots, it is part of their normal flying routine.

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Video feature

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Upcoming events & programs

Farnborough International Airshow
England, United Kingdom
July 20-24, 2026

Resources & career opportunities

First Officer B737
(Dubai | UAE)

Direct Entry First Officer
A320 family
(Bahrain | Bahrain)

Captain - A320 family
(Egypt | Cairo)

First Officer
Falcon 7X/8X
(Dubai | UAE)

First Officer Legacy
Praetor EMB-550
(Lebanon | Beirut)

First Officer
A320 family
(Jordan | Amman)

Pilot Cadet
B737 MAX
(Dubai | UAE)

First Officer Learjet
LR-60
(Saudi Arabia | Riyadh)

First Officer
Dash 8
(Abu Dhabi | UAE)

First Officer
Global Express
(Dubai | UAE)

Pilot Cadet
AC on Seniority
(Saudi Arabia | Riyadh)

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Quote of the month

“Pilots take no special joy in walking. Pilots like flying.”

Neil Armstrong

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